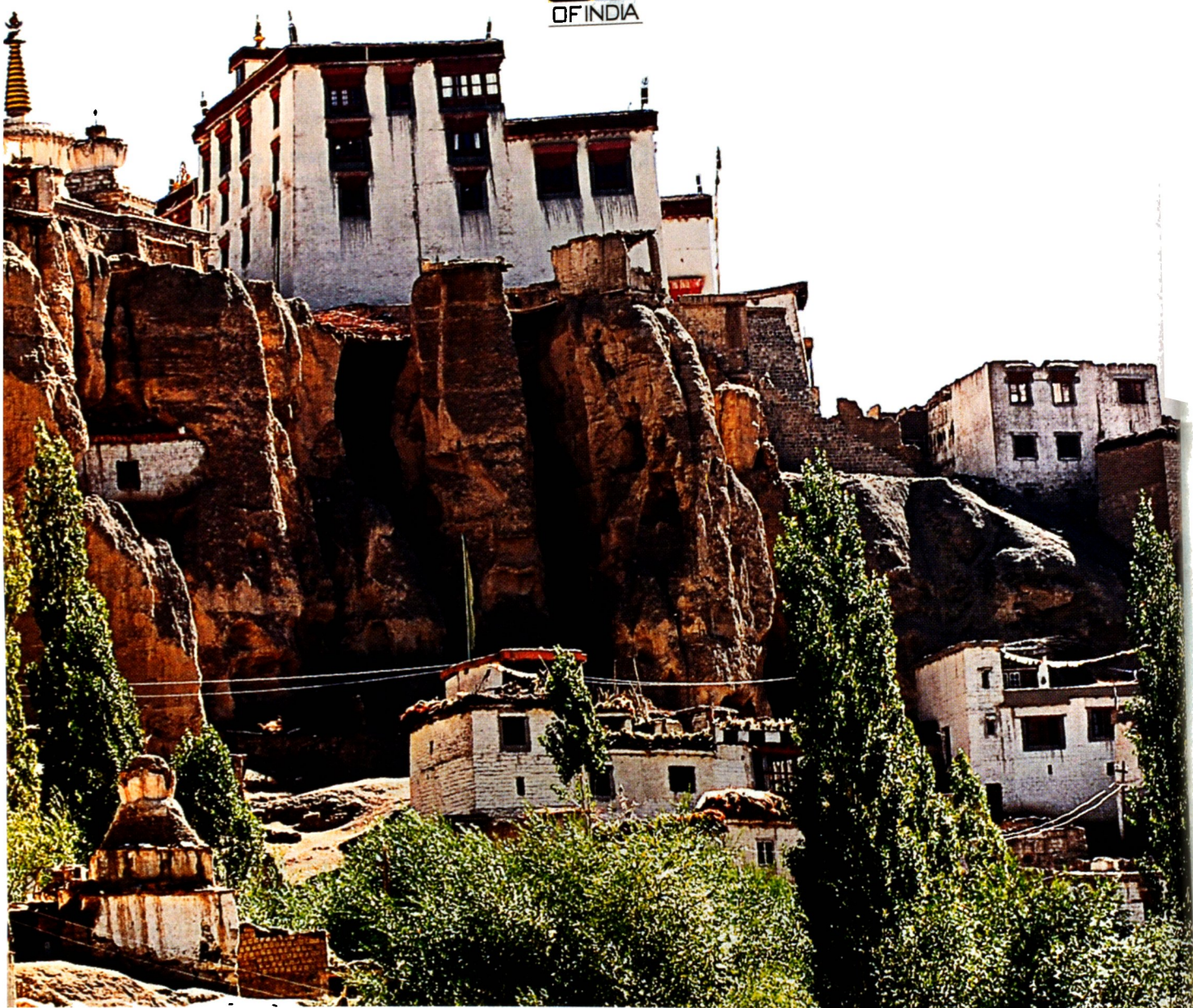




SANKAR SRIDHAR

SACRED HEIGHTS



SPECTACULAR MONASTERY LAMAYURU, LADAKH

It's a soul-lifting pilgrimage to spirituality and scenic splendour. Of several Buddhist monasteries dotting the stark and rugged landscape of Ladakh, Lamayuru stands out as the oldest of all and the most spectacular monastic seat in the region that is said to be the centre of ancient Bon religion. Tucked on the edge of a steep rock hemmed in by barren, craggy mountains jutting into the azure sky, this sprawling monastery is situated 120 km from Leh, just short of Fatu-La, the highest pass on the Leh-Srinagar highway. "Lamayuru is a fantastic repository of the rich legacy of Ladakh and has ancient wall paintings comparable to the Ajanta caves," says Nawang Tsering Shakspo, head of the Jammu and Kashmir Academy of Art, Culture and Language, at Leh. Lamayuru was founded by saint Naropa in the 9th century. It has now emerged as a hot tourist destination in the cold desert of Ladakh.

by Ramesh Vinayak

LEGEND HAS IT
THAT NAROPA
DRAINED A LAKE
TO PAVE THE
WAY FOR HIS
DISCIPLES
TO RAISE A
MONASTERY.